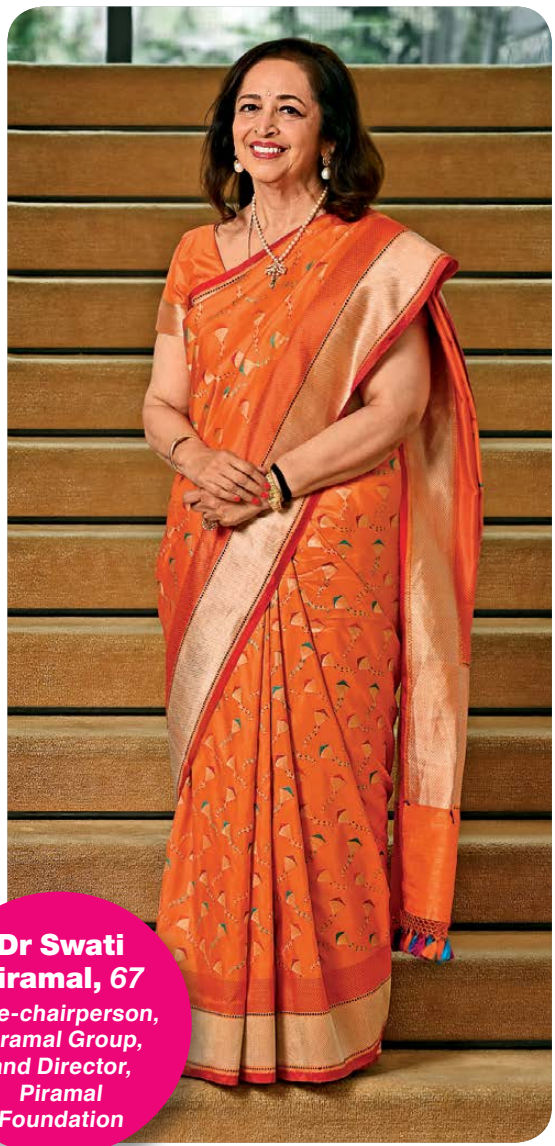
A Healing Hand



Dr Swati Piramal, *67*
Vice-chairperson, Piramal Group, and Director, Piramal Foundation

MANDAR DEODHAR

AS A MEDICAL STUDENT at the KEM Hospital, Mumbai, Swati Piramal was moved by the sight of a polio-struck girl, paralysed from the neck down. The resolve to ensure that polio vaccines reached the needy led to her first tryst with public health. She and her friends worked among the textile mill workers in the city's Lower Parel area, vaccinating the children and spreading awareness about polio. Initially, they met with resistance from the workers, but husband Ajay Piramal's father, Gopikisan Piramal, who owned Morarjee Textiles, promised an incentive in the form of dress material for all those who took all three doses of the vaccine. The incentive worked, and very soon, the area became a no-polio zone. A stint at the Harvard School of Public Health, at the age of 37 (she was a mother of two by then), exposed her to the latest in public healthcare.

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Has leveraged her medical skills and corporate experience to drive social initiatives, especially in public healthcare, education

By 1988, Ajay had acquired Nicholas Laboratories. The move brought Dr Piramal closer to pharma research, leading to the Piramals buying the Hoechst Research Centre. But India wasn't tuned in to new chemical entities or molecules, and the policies promoted generic medicines. "I think I was far ahead of my time on the research front," says Piramal.

At the Piramal Foundation that she spearheads, the focus is on health, education and water. Pratham, the education initiative, looks at training the leadership—headmasters, for instance—so that education outcomes are better and measurable. At KEM, she has initiated a leadership training programme for medical students, where they conduct field research on diseases in villages where health indicators are the bleakest. The other is the creation of electronic health records in villages and hospitals in 20 states. Sarvajal, a mission to provide safe drinking water, was started by her son Anand. She believes that leadership, technology and *seva bhav* can do wonders in public healthcare. "Once you get that right, the country's infection levels will be much lower, and we will have lower infant and maternal mortality numbers," she says. ■

-M.G. Arun

LIFE MOTTO

"Learn new things, act with compassion and care. Be yourself, so that the values you embody also reflect in your actions"

↘ ASANA QUEEN
Practises yoga *nidra* regularly, a meditative technique she mastered from yoga guru B.K.S. Iyengar

↘ BACKSTAGE
Working on a play that recreates her days as a medical student